AGENT ECONOMICS · OCT 28, 2026

97% of tokens are just rereading old context

You pay for amnesia, not for new work

WHY IT HAPPENS

- models are stateless between calls
- every tool call resends the whole history
- history grows, so each step costs more
- fresh generation is under 1% of tokens

THREE INDEPENDENT MEASUREMENTS

97%

of tokens are cache reads

97.0% one dev · 97.4% over 1.36B · 97.2% over 471 sessions

THE BILL TELLS ANOTHER STORY

- cache read: 97% of tokens, 46% of cost
- cache write: 2.8% of tokens, 38% of cost
- one rewrite costs like 40 cheap reads
- cost follows invalidation, not volume

WHAT TO DO

- put stable content first in the prompt
- keep volatile content at the very end
- never edit the head of the context mid-run
- trim tool output, push detail to subagents

TAKEAWAY

Optimize cache invalidation, not the number of tokens

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